Russia resulted in the Treaty of Aigun of 1858. This treaty reversed the terms of the earlier Treaty of Nerchinsk (1689), transferring the Amur river valley to Russia, though for some reason it was to remain under joint jurisdiction. In 1860, the Treaty of Beijing removed such ambiguity, with Russian sovereignty established over the entire basin and the port of Vladivostok being conceded to Russia.

Towards the end of the nineteenth century, a Japan with its economy and military modernized and expanded, thanks to the reforms of the Meiji Restoration, also joined in the depredations against China being committed by the Western powers. The Sino-Japanese war of 1894–95 took place as a result of competing claims for influence over Korea, which China long regarded as one of its most important tributary states. The defeat of the Qing forces by Japan resulted in the Treaty of Shimonoseki of 1895, whereby both China and Japan recognized the independence of Korea and China had to cede to Japan the island of Formosa (Taiwan) and the Pescadore Islands in the Taiwan Strait, which are known as Penghu in Chinese. More significantly, Japan also gained control over the strategically important Liaodong Peninsula, which is the southern part of Manchuria, but had to give it back to China under pressure from Western powers and Russia, who became alarmed at Japan’s imperial expansion in the east. A huge indemnity of 200 million taels (US$4.5 billion at 2018 prices) was extracted by Japan from a weak Chinese government. A further 30 million taels (approximately US$775 million at 2018 prices) was added in compensation for having to return Liaodong to China. It should also be noted that while insisting on being granted the same concessions as had been won by the Western powers in the treaty ports on the Chinese coast, Japan obtained privileged access to several important inland river ports, including Shashi (Hunan), Chongqing (Sichuan), Suzhou and Hangzhou (both in Jiangsu). This access to and growing familiarity with the important inland regions of China proved to be very useful to Japan during the subsequent Sino-Japanese war (1936–45).

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